

Personalisation as Affective Polarisation in Nigerian Adversarial Political Discourse (2021–2023)

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Abstract

Personalisation is a salient feature of contemporary political communication, yet its role in constructing affective polarisation remains underexamined in African political contexts. This study examines personalisation as a pragma-linguistic mechanism through which political actors construct identity, negotiate legitimacy, and intensify affective divisions in Nigerian adversarial political discourse during the 2021–2023 electoral period. The analysis draws on 171 purposively selected extracts from campaign speeches, televised debates, interviews, and press statements. An integrated framework combining Systemic Functional Grammar, Speech Act Theory, and socio-cultural analysis examines personal reference, naming, evaluative language, autobiographical narratives, presupposition, implicature, and self–other representation. Findings show that personalisation foregrounds political actors as legitimate and competent while portraying opponents as illegitimate, incompetent, or morally deficient. These strategies intersect with ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, and shared political memory to reinforce in-group/out-group distinctions. Personalisation therefore functions beyond self-presentation, organising affective attachments and intensifying adversarial alignments. The study highlights the importance of linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural processes in understanding affective polarisation in Nigeria.

Keywords: *personalisation; affective polarisation; adversarial political discourse; Nigerian political discourse; pragma-linguistics; political identity*

Introduction

Political communication is central to the construction and contestation of political meanings in democratic societies. As a site of political competition, discourse often involves the assertion of competing interests, identities, values, and claims to legitimacy. In adversarial political discourse, disagreement extends beyond policy differences to encompass the evaluation of political actors and their supporters, creating conditions for the construction of oppositional identities and antagonistic relations. Contemporary political competition increasingly centres on individual political actors rather than exclusively on parties, institutions, or policy programmes. Political leaders consequently become salient representations of political values, ideological commitments, and collective identities, with political evaluation focusing on competence, credibility, character, and leadership performance.

This actor-centred orientation is commonly described as personalisation. Personalisation is more than the increased visibility of political leaders; it is a discursive process through which political meanings, identities, and evaluations are organised around individuals. In adversarial contexts, political actors may become focal points for competing representations of legitimacy, competence, morality, and political entitlement.

Personalisation therefore provides a useful lens for examining how individual actors become associated with broader political positions and collective identities.

Personalisation is realised through a range of linguistic and pragmatic resources, including personal reference, naming, evaluative language, autobiographical narratives, presupposition, implicature, and self–other representation. Through these resources, political actors construct identities, negotiate legitimacy, foreground achievements, attribute responsibility, and position opponents negatively. First-person references and autobiographical accounts can foreground personal agency and achievement, while direct references to opponents and evaluative expressions can construct contrasting representations. Such strategies make political competition more actor-centred and provide discursive resources for organising political identification and opposition.

The identity-based character of such competition has implications for affective polarisation, which refers to the development of positive attachments towards political in-groups alongside negative orientations towards opposing groups. When political actors become symbolic markers of ideological, ethnic, religious, regional, or social affiliations, evaluations of individuals may extend to the groups they are perceived to represent. Personalised discourse can consequently encourage political choices and evaluations based on loyalty, trust, resentment, or identification, transforming individual political representation into broader affective alignment and opposition.

These dynamics were particularly salient in Nigerian political discourse during the 2021–2023 electoral period. Debates surrounding leadership succession, governance, national unity, representation, and democratic legitimacy frequently centred on individual political actors, their records, affiliations, and political claims. Such discourse was also shaped by ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, and shared political experiences and memories. Political actors were therefore represented not merely as individuals but as embodiments of collective interests, identities, aspirations, and grievances, linking personalised political evaluation to wider group-based divisions.

Although Nigerian political discourse has attracted considerable scholarly attention in relation to rhetoric, persuasion, ideological framing, campaign communication, and media representation (Aremu, 2017; Agbo et al., 2018; Osisanwo, 2020), the role of personalisation as a pragma-linguistic mechanism in the construction of affective polarisation remains comparatively underexplored. Existing studies have often examined linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural dimensions separately, providing limited explanation of how their interaction constructs personalised political meanings, self–other relations, and adversarial divisions. This gap is particularly significant in relation to the Nigerian context, where political identities intersect with complex socio-cultural affiliations.

This study examines personalisation as an integrated pragma-linguistic phenomenon in Nigerian adversarial political discourse during the 2021–2023 electoral period. Drawing on Systemic Functional Grammar, Speech Act Theory, and the Ethnography of Communication, it investigates how linguistic resources, communicative actions, and socio-cultural contexts construct political identities, negotiate legitimacy, produce self–other representations, and contribute to affective polarisation.

The study addresses three questions:

1. How is personalisation linguistically and pragmatically realised in Nigerian adversarial political discourse?
2. How do personalised discourse strategies construct political identities, negotiate legitimacy, delegitimise opponents, and contribute to affective polarisation?
3. How do socio-cultural identities and contextual factors influence the production and interpretation of personalised political discourse?

The study contributes by demonstrating how personalisation mediates the relationship between linguistic representation, political identity, and affective polarisation. It extends scholarship on political personalisation beyond predominantly Western contexts through evidence from Nigeria and demonstrates the value of integrating linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural perspectives in analysing political identity, legitimacy, and adversarial division.

Personalisation and Adversarial Political Discourse

Political discourse is a key site for constructing, negotiating, and contesting political meanings, identities, and relations. Its adversarial dimension (Bull & Mayer, 2021) involves advancing preferred positions while challenging opponents' credibility, competence, legitimacy, or intentions. Political discourse therefore entails not only disagreement over issues but also struggles over identity, authority, legitimacy, and group boundaries (Chilton, 2004; van Dijk, 2006).

A significant feature of contemporary political communication is the increasing prominence of individual political actors, commonly termed personalisation. Personalisation foregrounds politicians' personalities, leadership qualities, experiences, character, and credibility, making them objects of political evaluation and identification (McAllister, 2007; Langer, 2010; Stanyer, 2013; Van Aelst et al., 2017). Political actors may consequently become embodiments of political values, projects, and identities rather than merely representatives of parties or institutions.

In adversarial discourse, personalisation extends beyond political visibility to the linguistic and pragmatic construction of political actors. Personal reference, naming, evaluation, autobiographical narratives, and self–other representation can foreground agency, attribute qualities, establish authority, and distinguish legitimate from illegitimate actors. Presupposition and implicature may further communicate evaluations and assumptions indirectly. Personalisation is thus a pragma-linguistic process through which political identities and legitimacy are constructed and contested within competing representations of self and other.

Its relationship with affective polarisation is particularly significant. When politicians become symbolic representatives of broader ethnic, religious, regional, partisan, or ideological identities, evaluations of individuals may acquire collective significance. Approval of a political actor can reinforce group identification, while criticism may intensify opposition towards associated groups. Despite extensive scholarship on political personalisation, less attention has been given to how linguistic and pragmatic processes interact with socio-cultural identities to produce such affective divisions. This study addresses this gap by examining personalisation as a pragma-

linguistic process through which political identity, legitimacy, and affective alignment are constructed in Nigerian adversarial political discourse.

Personalisation as Linguistic, Pragmatic and Socio-cultural Practice

Personalisation extends beyond political visibility to the discursive construction of political identities through which individual actors become objects of evaluation, identification, and opposition. In adversarial discourse, personal reference, naming, evaluative language, autobiographical narratives, self–other representation, speech acts, presupposition, and implicature enable political actors to foreground themselves, characterise opponents, and negotiate legitimacy. Their meanings are shaped by the socio-cultural contexts in which political communication occurs.

Identity construction is central to personalisation. Bamberg (2005) views identity as constructed through discourse and interaction, while van Dijk (1998) highlights positive self-presentation and negative other-presentation in ideological identity construction. Personal reference, naming, and autobiographical narratives can foreground agency, experience, achievement, competence, and moral standing, enabling politicians to establish credibility and distinguish themselves from opponents.

Evaluation further shapes personalised identities. Evaluative language assigns value to persons, actions, and events and positions audiences towards preferred interpretations (Martin & White, 2005). Political actors may therefore be associated with competence, integrity, patriotism, or credibility, while opponents are represented through incompetence, dishonesty, failure, or moral deficiency. Personalisation consequently contributes to the affective evaluation of political actors.

Pragmatic action also constitutes personalisation. Speech Act Theory (Austin, 1962; Searle, 1969) explains how representatives, directives, commissives, expressives, and declaratives perform political actions, while presupposition and implicature communicate assumptions and evaluations beyond explicit utterances.

These resources are mediated by socio-cultural context. Hymes' (1974) *Ethnography of Communication* shows how participants, purposes, norms, settings, and shared knowledge shape meaning. In Nigeria, ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, party loyalty, and political history may connect individual actors with wider group identities. Personalisation therefore functions as an integrated pragma-linguistic and socio-cultural practice through which political identities, legitimacy, adversarial relations, and affective alignments are constructed within historically situated and culturally meaningful patterns of political interaction.

Personalisation and Affective Polarisation

The relationship between personalisation and affective polarisation becomes significant when political actors are constructed as representatives of broader political and social identities. Personalisation makes individual politicians salient objects of evaluation, while affective polarisation involves positive orientations towards aligned groups and negative orientations towards opposing groups. When politicians become symbolic representatives of particular identities, evaluations of individuals may extend to the groups, values, and interests they are perceived to represent.

Self–other construction is central to this process. Political actors may present themselves as competent, credible, experienced, committed, or legitimate while representing opponents through negative evaluations of their character, competence, motives, or records. Such representations establish boundaries between desirable and undesirable political actors, with the legitimacy of the political self-reinforced through contrast with the oppositional other. Personalisation can therefore contribute to affective polarisation when these distinctions acquire emotional and group-based significance.

Nigerian scholarship provides evidence for these processes. Opeibi (2021) shows how self-referential narratives and autobiographical accounts project competence, credibility, accessibility, and shared experience. Osisanwo (2016) demonstrates the role of evaluation and metaphorical framing in positive self- and negative other-presentation, while Adegoju and Adetunji (2020) highlight emotional appeals that evoke trust, hope, admiration, distrust, and resentment. These studies establish important links among personal representation, evaluation, emotion, and political alignment.

The affective consequences become more pronounced where political actors are associated with ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, party loyalty, zoning, and shared political memory. Individual evaluations may consequently acquire collective significance, reinforcing in-group identification or activating perceptions of an out-group. However, limited attention has been given to how these linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural processes interact to transform individual actors into focal points of affective alignment and opposition. This study addresses this gap by examining personalisation as a discursive mechanism linking individual and collective political identities through self–other representation and affective differentiation within Nigeria’s contested electoral and socio-political environment.

Theoretical Framework

Personalisation in adversarial political discourse involves linguistic form, communicative action, and socio-cultural context. The study therefore integrates Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG), Speech Act Theory (SAT), and Hymes’ Ethnography of Communication (EoC) to examine how political actors construct identity, negotiate legitimacy, position opponents, and generate affective alignments.

1. Systemic Functional Grammar

Systemic Functional Grammar (Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014) views language as a social semiotic resource for constructing meaning. It provides the linguistic basis for analysing personalisation through grammatical and lexical choices. The interpersonal meta-function is particularly relevant to personal pronouns, naming, modality, and evaluative language, while transitivity reveals how political actors are represented through process types and participant roles. Modality indicates degrees of certainty, commitment, obligation, and authority, while appraisal illuminates evaluative positioning. SFG therefore identifies how personalisation is linguistically realised and how actors are positioned in relation to one another within political discourse and interaction.

2. Speech Act Theory

Speech Act Theory (Austin, 1962; Searle, 1969) conceptualises language as social action and explains what political actors accomplish through personalised utterances. Representative, directive, commissive, expressive, and declarative acts enable speakers to assert claims, mobilise audiences, express attitudes, make commitments, and establish political meanings. Accusations, praise, criticism, defence, and legitimising claims similarly function as political actions through which actors construct their status and challenge opponents. SAT therefore explains the pragmatic functions of personalised linguistic choices in constructing political identities and legitimacy.

3. Ethnography of Communication

Hymes' (1974) Ethnography of Communication situates linguistic and pragmatic meanings within their socio-cultural contexts. Its SPEAKING model considers settings, participants, purposes, norms, and genres that shape communicative events. In Nigerian political discourse, ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, party loyalty, zoning, succession, and shared political experience may influence how personalised representations are produced and interpreted. EoC therefore provides the contextual basis for understanding their political and cultural significance within specific socio-political communicative contexts.

4. Integration and Analytical Model

Following Ayoola's (2008) pragma-functional orientation, the study integrates SFG, SAT, and EoC. SFG identifies the linguistic realisation of personalisation; SAT explains the political actions performed through these forms; and EoC accounts for the socio-cultural contexts shaping their production and interpretation. The integrated model therefore traces how linguistic representation becomes communicative action within particular contexts and how these processes construct political identity, legitimacy, self–other relations, and affective alignment within Nigeria's adversarial political discourse context.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative pragma-linguistic discourse-analytic design within an interpretive paradigm to examine how personalisation constructs political identities, negotiates legitimacy, and contributes to affective polarisation. The approach focuses on the interaction of linguistic choices, pragmatic actions, and socio-cultural contexts rather than the frequency of linguistic features.

The corpus comprises 171 purposively selected extracts from Nigerian political discourse produced between 2021 and 2023, including campaign speeches, televised debates, press statements, and media interviews. Sources were drawn from verified media organisations, official political communication channels, and publicly accessible archives. Extracts were selected where they contained personalisation through personal reference, naming, autobiographical narratives, evaluative representation, or self–other construction, particularly in discourse concerning leadership, legitimacy, governance, zoning, ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, and political representation. The study focuses on elite political discourse because political elites play influential roles in shaping public political narratives.

Analysis integrates Ayoola's (2008) pragma-functional orientation with SFG, SAT, and EoC. Four stages were employed: (1) SFG identified pronouns, naming, transitivity, modality, appraisal, and interpersonal positioning; (2) SAT examined representative, directive, commissive, expressive, and declarative acts, including relevant presuppositions and implicatures; (3) EoC situated these findings within communicative and socio-cultural contexts, including ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, party loyalty, and political memory; and (4) integrated interpretation examined how linguistic representations and pragmatic actions, within specific contexts, constructed identity, legitimacy, self–other distinctions, and affective alignments. Units of analysis included clauses, clause complexes, evaluative constructions, speech-act configurations, and personalised references.

Table 3.1. Integrated Analytical Procedure

Analytical Stage	Framework	Analytical Focus	Analytical Outcome
Stage 1	Systemic Functional Grammar	Personal reference, naming, transitivity, participant roles, modality, appraisal, interpersonal meanings	Linguistic realisation of personalisation, identity, agency, and evaluation
Stage 2	Speech Act Theory	Representative, directive, commissive, expressive, and declarative acts; presupposition and implicature	Communicative actions, legitimacy claims, criticism, mobilisation, and political positioning
Stage 3	Ethnography of Communication	Setting, participants, purposes, genre, norms, shared knowledge, and socio-cultural affiliations	Contextual interpretation of personalised political meanings
Stage 4	Integrated interpretation	Interaction of linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural findings	Explanation of personalisation, self–other positioning, political alignment, and affective polarisation

Trustworthiness and Ethical Considerations

Trustworthiness was enhanced through systematic application of SFG, SAT, and EoC and comparison of linguistic, pragmatic, and contextual patterns across political actors and genres. Theoretical triangulation enabled these dimensions to be examined in relation to one another. Data were drawn exclusively from publicly available political texts obtained from verified sources. Ethical considerations focused on analysing discourse practices rather than making personal or normative judgements about political actors or organisations, thereby supporting a systematic and contextually grounded interpretation of personalisation and affective polarisation.

Data Analysis and Findings

This section presents findings from 171 purposively selected extracts of Nigerian adversarial political discourse produced between 2021 and 2023. Consistent with Section 3.3, analysis proceeded through four stages: SFG examined the linguistic realisation of personalisation; SAT identified the communicative actions performed; EoC situated these patterns within their socio-cultural contexts; and integrated analysis examined how linguistic resources, pragmatic actions, and contextual meanings jointly constructed political identity, legitimacy, adversarial self–other representations, and affective polarisation.

Systemic Functional Grammar: Linguistic Realisation of Personalisation

The first stage applied Systemic Functional Grammar (SFG) to identify how personalisation was linguistically realised through personal pronouns, naming, transitivity, modality, appraisal, and interpersonal meanings. The analysis examined how these resources foregrounded political actors, attributed agency and responsibility, expressed authority and evaluation, and constructed self–other positions.

1. Personal Pronouns and Self-Reference

First-person forms such as *I*, *me*, and *my* foregrounded speakers' experiences, achievements, commitments, and political claims. In *My record speaks for itself: I delivered projects that changed lives across this nation*, *my* and *I* directly associate the speaker with the claimed achievement, constructing personal agency and competence. First-person plural forms such as *we* and *our* extended personalisation to collective identity. In *Our people have been marginalised for too long*, *our* connects the speaker with a wider community, linking individual political claims to collective experience and interests.

2. Naming Practices and Political Identification

Naming practices made political actors salient through personal names, titles, offices, and recognisable political designations. Such references associated individuals with particular actions, qualities, records, and political positions. For example, references such as *Asiwaju Bola Tinubu*, *Atiku Abubakar*, *Peter Obi*, *President Muhammadu Buhari*, and “Governor Nyesom Wike” foregrounded individuals as identifiable political actors while simultaneously activating their offices, political histories, and public identities. Honorifics and political titles such as *Asiwaju*, *President*, *Governor*, and *former Vice-President* could confer institutional authority or political status. Conversely, labels such as *the opposition*, *failed leadership*, or *political godfather* could categorise opponents through negatively evaluated identities. Naming therefore functioned not merely as reference but as a resource for associating individuals with particular political roles, achievements, failures, values, and affiliations. References to opponents could simultaneously place them within negatively evaluated categories, making naming a resource for constructing political identification and self–other distinctions.

3. Transitivity and Participant Roles

Transitivity showed how political actors were represented as agents, affected participants, beneficiaries, or sources of political problems. Material processes were particularly prominent in representations of achievement and action. In *I delivered projects that changed lives across this nation*, the speaker functions as Actor of *delivered*, foregrounding personal responsibility for the reported outcome. Similarly, *I built roads and improved schools in my constituency* positions the speaker as Actor and the constituency as the Beneficiary of political action. In *we created opportunities for young Nigerians*, the collective *we* functions as Actor, while *young Nigerians* occupy the Beneficiary role, constructing the political group as responsive to citizens' needs.

Conversely, constructions such as *they failed to protect our communities* represent opponents as Actors responsible for an undesirable outcome. In *Nigerians suffered under their leadership*, *Nigerians* are represented as Affected participants, while *their leadership* is associated with responsibility for the situation. Relational processes also constructed political identities, as in *I am a leader who delivers* and *he is an ineffective leader*, which respectively attribute desirable and undesirable qualities to political actors. Verbal processes similarly foregrounded political agency in expressions such as *I promised to restore confidence* or *they accused me of failure*. Passive constructions, such as *our communities were neglected*, can background the responsible actor while foregrounding those affected.

These participant configurations enabled speakers to attribute agency, responsibility, success, failure, benefit, or victimhood to political actors, thereby shaping personalised representations of competence, accountability, and legitimacy. Such choices illustrate how transitivity can construct political actors and their roles through selective foregrounding and backgrounding of participants.

4. Modality and Political Authority

Modality expressed degrees of certainty, obligation, possibility, and commitment. Expressions such as *must*, *should*, and *will* positioned speakers in relation to authority, necessity, and future action. In personalised discourse, such choices could construct political actors as decisive, committed, responsible, and capable of directing political outcomes.

5. Appraisal and Evaluative Representation

Appraisal resources constructed positive and negative representations of political actors. Positive evaluations associated preferred actors with competence, experience, integrity, sacrifice, patriotism, and achievement, while negative evaluations associated opponents with failure, incompetence, dishonesty, exclusion, or inadequate leadership. In *My record speaks for itself*, competence is implied through reference to achievement rather than stated directly. Appraisal therefore shaped political characterisation and audience positioning.

6. Interpersonal Meaning and Self–Other Positioning

Collectively, these resources constructed interpersonal relations and recurring self–other distinctions. Pronouns established relations among speakers, opponents, and audiences. For example, expressions such as *I have served this country* foregrounded the speaker's personal agency and experience, while *we will rebuild Nigeria* positioned the speaker within a collective political identity. Conversely, references such as *they have failed Nigerians* constructed opponents as responsible for perceived failures.

Naming further foregrounded political actors and associated them with particular offices, records, or political identities. Transitivity similarly attributed agency and responsibility, as in *we delivered* and *they destroyed*, which constructed contrasting representations of political action. Modality expressed authority and commitment through forms such as *we must act* and *I will deliver*, while appraisal assigned positive or negative value through descriptions such as *competent leadership* and *failed leadership*. Collectively, these choices positioned political actors as credible, responsible, competent, or legitimate while constructing opponents in contrasting terms. Personalisation consequently operated as a patterned linguistic process through which political actors became focal points of identity, evaluation, and legitimacy, providing the linguistic basis for the pragmatic analysis in Stage Two.

Speech Act Analysis of Personalisation

The second stage applied Speech Act Theory (SAT) to examine the political actions performed through personalised discourse. Building on the linguistic patterns identified in Stage One, the analysis examined how speakers used personalised constructions to assert claims, establish credibility, make commitments, evaluate opponents, express attitudes, and mobilise audiences. Personalisation therefore functioned not merely as representation but as political action through which identity, legitimacy, authority, and adversarial relations were negotiated.

1. Representative Acts and Political Legitimacy

Representative acts enabled political actors to present achievements, experiences, abilities, and political positions as credible grounds for support. In *My record speaks for itself: I delivered projects that changed lives across this nation*, the speaker asserts personal achievement as evidence of competence and legitimacy. Similarly, *When others failed, I stepped forward to restore confidence in government* combines positive self-representation with negative evaluation of others. Representative acts thus constructed political identity through claims about achievement and competence.

2. Commissive Acts and Political Commitment

Commissive acts expressed future-oriented commitments. In *I will continue to fight for justice and fairness, I* identifies the speaker as the source of the commitment, while *will continue* projects future action. Such constructions represented political actors as determined, responsible, and committed to particular values. Personalisation therefore extended from past achievements to projected political action.

3. Expressive Acts and Political Evaluation

Expressive acts communicated approval, criticism, dissatisfaction, solidarity, and other attitudes. In *Our people deserve better than the leadership they have received*, the speaker negatively evaluates existing leadership while expressing support for an improved condition. Similarly, *When others failed, I stepped forward* combines criticism of others with favourable self-positioning. Expressives consequently contributed to affective evaluation of political actors.

4. Directive Acts and Audience Mobilisation

Directives sought to influence audience beliefs or actions by urging support, rejection, participation, or particular political responses. Personalised directives positioned speakers as authoritative actors capable of advising, persuading, or mobilising audiences, thereby strengthening claims to leadership and political legitimacy. Examples included expressions such as *Vote for me*, *Support our movement*, *Reject those who have failed you*, and *Join us in rebuilding Nigeria*. Such directives explicitly connected the requested action to the political actor issuing it. Similarly, expressions such as *Let us reclaim our country* constructed solidarity by combining a directive orientation with collective identification, while *Do not vote for them* established an oppositional self–other distinction. These constructions demonstrate that personalised directives did more than request political action; they positioned speakers as agents of change, invited audiences into particular political alignments, and reinforced distinctions between preferred and opposing political actors.

5. Declarative Acts and Political Positioning

Declaratives were used to establish or redefine political positions, situations, or relationships. Personalised declarative constructions positioned speakers as authoritative participants capable of defining political realities and challenging the legitimacy or status of opponents. Examples include statements such as *I am the candidate who will lead Nigeria*, *This is my mandate*, and *We are the legitimate representatives of the people*. Such constructions presented political claims as established realities rather than merely personal opinions. Similarly, expressions such as *They have lost the confidence of Nigerians* or *He is not fit to lead* functioned to redefine opponents' political status and legitimacy. Declarative formulations such as *I accept this responsibility* could also establish a speaker's commitment to a political role. These examples show how declarative acts enabled political actors to assert authority, define political realities, legitimise themselves, and delegitimise opponents through personalised positioning.

6. Presupposition, Implicature, and Indirect Personalisation

Presupposition and implicature extended personalised meanings beyond explicit propositions. *My record speaks for itself* presupposes an established record and invites the inference that the speaker is competent and deserving of support. Similarly, *I have done what others only promised* presupposes a contrast between the speaker's achievements and opponents' unfulfilled commitments, while *Nigerians know who delivered when it mattered* presupposes an identifiable record of performance and implicates the speaker's competence. *If I had failed, would people still be asking me to lead?* presupposes continuing public confidence and indirectly constructs the speaker as electable and legitimate. Conversely, *Those who could not fix the problem now want another chance* presupposes previous failure and implicates opponents' lack of competence. *We all remember what happened under their leadership* activates shared political memory without explicitly naming the alleged failures. Likewise, *The people deserve better than what they have experienced* indirectly evaluates the current or opposing leadership while positioning the speaker as an alternative. Such constructions enabled political actors to communicate favourable or unfavourable evaluations indirectly, allowing audiences to infer competence, failure, legitimacy, or unworthiness from shared assumptions and contextual knowledge. These indirect meanings therefore contributed to personalised self–other positioning without requiring explicit evaluative claims.

7. Personalisation as Political Action

Overall, representative acts established claims to achievement and legitimacy; commissives projected commitment; expressives communicated evaluation; directives mobilised audiences; and declaratives asserted political positions. Presupposition and implicature reinforced these meanings indirectly. These acts frequently organised contrasts between political self and other, demonstrating that personalisation functions pragmatically as a means of performing political identity and legitimacy rather than merely describing political actors.

Ethnography of Communication: Socio-cultural Contexts of Personalisation

The third stage examined how the linguistic and pragmatic features identified in Stages One and Two were situated within Nigerian socio-cultural contexts. Drawing on Hymes' (1974) Ethnography of Communication and the SPEAKING model, the analysis considered communicative settings, participants, purposes, norms, and shared knowledge. Particular attention was given to electoral competition, leadership expectations, ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, political succession, and shared political experience. The findings show that personalised meanings were shaped by wider identities, interests, and expectations through which political actors and their utterances were interpreted.

1. Campaign and Electoral Contexts

Campaign speeches, debates, media interviews, and press statements constituted the principal settings in the corpus. These contexts were characterised by competition, persuasion, candidate evaluation, and appeals for electoral support. In *My record speaks for itself: I delivered projects that changed lives across this nation*, personal achievement becomes a basis for electoral evaluation, while *I will continue to fight for justice and fairness* places the individual speaker at the centre of projected political action. Campaign contexts therefore reinforced the association between individual political identity and electoral choice.

2. Leadership, Legitimacy, and Political Expectations

Leadership expectations shaped the interpretation of personal achievements, experience, sacrifice, service, competence, and commitment. *My record speaks for itself*, for example, derives significance from an expectation that previous performance demonstrates leadership suitability. Similarly, commitments to justice, fairness, development, and public service connect individual political identities with broader expectations of legitimate leadership. Personalisation thus linked individual attributes to culturally recognised criteria of political competence and deservingness.

3. Ethnicity, Religion, and Regional Affiliation

Ethnicity, religion, and regional affiliation provided important contexts for personalised political meanings. In *Our people deserve better than the leadership they have received*, the possessive *our* connects the speaker with a wider community and frames political evaluation as a collective concern. Similarly, *A Muslim-Muslim ticket cannot reflect the diversity of our nation* places individual political actors within broader debates about religious representation and inclusion. Regional affiliations operated similarly by connecting political actors with geographical communities and perceived interests. Personalisation could therefore extend from individual identity to collective representation.

4. Zoning, Succession, and Representation

Zoning and political succession provided contextual frameworks for claims concerning leadership, fairness, entitlement, and representation. *It is my turn to lead this country after years of sacrifice and service* connects individual political aspiration with expectations surrounding succession and previous service. Likewise, *The presidency should return to the South in the interest of fairness and national unity* links leadership with regional representation. Such constructions demonstrate how individual political claims may simultaneously invoke collective expectations concerning rotation, inclusion, and national balance.

5. Shared Political Memory and Experience

Shared political memory provided interpretive resources for evaluating present political actors. References to previous administrations, achievements, failures, marginalisation, and political sacrifice enabled audiences to interpret personalised claims against broader narratives of political experience. In *When others failed, I stepped forward to restore confidence in government*, the speaker's positive identity depends partly on an implied history of failure. Personalisation could therefore position actors as continuations of, alternatives to, or responses to previous political conditions.

6. Participants, Audience Alignment, and Political Identification

Political actors addressed audiences as members of communities sharing political, regional, religious, ethnic, or national identities. Inclusive forms such as *our people* established proximity, while *they*, *others*, and references to political groups could establish in-group/out-group boundaries. When speakers presented themselves as members, representatives, or defenders of particular communities, personalisation became connected to collective political identification.

7. Socio-cultural Mediation of Personalisation

The EoC analysis demonstrates that personalised meanings were embedded in communicative settings and socio-cultural expectations. Electoral competition foregrounded personal achievements; leadership norms shaped evaluations of individual claims; ethnicity, religion, and regional affiliation connected actors to collective identities; zoning and succession framed claims of representation; and shared political memory informed evaluations of present actors. Personalisation therefore operated within a socio-cultural environment where individual political actors could become symbolic representatives of wider communities and interests, linking individual evaluation with collective identification and providing a basis for the affective alignments examined in Stage Four.

Integrated Findings: Interaction of Personalisation and Affective Polarisation

The fourth stage integrates the linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural findings to explain how personalisation contributes to affective polarisation in Nigerian adversarial political discourse. SFG identifies how political actors are represented, SAT explains the actions performed through these representations, and EoC situates them within relevant socio-cultural contexts. The findings indicate that personalisation becomes consequential when individual actors are constructed as embodiments of particular achievements, values, communities, or interests, while opponents are associated with failure, exclusion, or undesirable outcomes.

1. Interaction of Linguistic, Pragmatic, and Socio-cultural Resources

In *My record speaks for itself: I delivered projects that changed lives across this nation*, *my* and *I* foreground the speaker, while *delivered* attributes agency and *changed lives* presents a positive outcome. Pragmatically, the utterance functions as a representative claim in which achievement provides evidence of competence. Contextually, it occurs within electoral discourse where personal records influence leadership evaluation. Linguistic self-representation therefore becomes a claim to legitimacy within a specific political setting.

Similarly, *When others failed, I stepped forward to restore confidence in government* constructs contrasting participant positions through *others* and *I*. The processes *failed*, *stepped forward*, and *restore* represent opposing forms of political action. Pragmatically, the utterance asserts personal competence while negatively evaluating others. Within leadership contexts, the speaker is positioned as an alternative to perceived political failure.

In *Our people have been marginalised for too long, and this election is an opportunity to correct that injustice*, *our* links the speaker with a wider community, while *marginalised* and *injustice* construct a shared political grievance. The statement functions both as a representation of political conditions and an appeal for corrective action. Its meaning therefore connects individual political identity with collective experience.

2. Personalisation, Legitimacy, and Political Identity

Political legitimacy was frequently constructed through personalised representations of achievement, experience, commitment, and leadership capacity. *My record speaks for itself* presents personal performance as a source of credibility, while *I will continue to fight for justice and fairness* constructs a future-oriented identity based on commitment to positively valued principles. Legitimacy was also established contrastively, as in *When others failed, I stepped forward*, where personal competence is strengthened through the negative representation of others. Personalisation thus transformed past performance and projected action into resources for individual political legitimacy.

3. Personalisation and Collective Political Identification

Personalised discourse frequently intersected with collective identities. In *Our people have been marginalised for too long*, the speaker's individual identity is connected to a wider community through *our*. Similarly, *A Muslim-Muslim ticket cannot reflect the diversity of our nation* places political actors within broader questions of religious representation and national inclusion. *The presidency should return to the South in the interest of fairness and national unity* similarly links leadership with regional representation and collective political values. Personalisation therefore provided a bridge between individual actors and wider group interests.

4. Self–Other Construction and Affective Alignment

Affective polarisation became visible through contrasting representations of political selves and others. In *They want to divide this nation, but we will unite it*, *they* and *we* establish opposing groups, while *divide* and *unite* attribute contrasting political intentions and actions. The speaker's group is associated with cohesion and the opposing group with fragmentation. Similar constructions associated political actors with competence, justice, inclusion, and achievement while linking opponents with failure, exclusion, or incompetence.

5. Personalisation as a Mechanism of Affective Polarisation

The integrated findings indicate a cumulative process: linguistic resources foreground political actors and assign positive or negative attributes; pragmatic actions transform these representations into claims, commitments, evaluations, accusations, and appeals; and socio-cultural contexts connect individual actors with ethnic, religious, regional, partisan, and national identities. Individual evaluations can consequently acquire collective significance.

Personalisation therefore contributes to affective polarisation when political actors become symbolic representatives of competing identities and values. Positive self-representations may encourage identification and solidarity, whereas negative representations of opponents may generate distrust or opposition. Personalised discourse consequently does more than describe political actors: through the interaction of linguistic representation, pragmatic action, and socio-cultural meaning, it constructs competing political identities and affective alignments.

Discussion of Findings

The findings demonstrate that personalisation in Nigerian adversarial political discourse is a pragma-linguistic and socio-culturally situated process through which political actors are constructed, evaluated, legitimised, and opposed. Across Sections 4.1–4.4, linguistic choices foregrounded political actors, pragmatic actions attached political force to these representations, and socio-cultural contexts connected individuals with wider identities and interests. The discussion therefore interprets the findings in relation to the study's theoretical perspectives and existing scholarship.

1. Linguistic Realisation of Personalisation

The SFG findings show that personalisation was realised through pronouns, naming, transitivity, modality, appraisal, and interpersonal positioning. First-person forms such as *I* and *my* foregrounded individual agency and achievement, while *we* and *our* extended personal identity to wider communities. This supports Halliday and Matthiessen's (2014) view of language as a resource for constructing social meanings. Transitivity further represented speakers as agents of desirable actions and opponents as associated with failure or undesirable outcomes. Modality and appraisal reinforced these representations by expressing commitment, authority, and positive or negative evaluation.

These findings extend research on political personalisation (McAllister, 2007; Langer, 2010; Stanyer, 2013; Van Aelst et al., 2017) by demonstrating that personalisation is not simply increased attention to politicians but is actively constructed through grammatical and evaluative choices. The findings therefore identify the linguistic mechanisms through which individual political actors become salient objects of political judgement.

2. Personalisation as Political Action

The SAT findings further demonstrate that personalised constructions perform political actions. Representative acts established claims to achievement and competence; commissives projected commitment; directives sought audience mobilisation; expressives communicated approval or criticism; and declaratives positioned speakers as authoritative participants in political affairs. This accords with Austin's (1962) and Searle's (1969) conception of language as action.

Importantly, personalisation attached these actions directly to identifiable political actors. A claim to achievement consequently became a claim to competence, while a commitment projected the speaker as dependable and politically purposeful. Presupposition and implicature also enabled indirect evaluation. Thus, *My record speaks for itself* invites an inference of competence, whereas *When others failed, I stepped forward* constructs positive self-presentation through negative other-presentation. The finding extends Nigerian political discourse scholarship by showing how personalised representation becomes a means of performing legitimacy, criticism, commitment, and mobilisation.

3. Socio-cultural Mediation

The EoC findings demonstrate that personalised meanings are shaped by the socio-cultural contexts in which political communication occurs. Campaigns, debates, interviews, and press statements provided settings in which leadership credentials and personal achievements became politically salient. In accordance with Hymes' (1974) framework, participants, purposes, norms, and shared knowledge influenced the interpretation of these constructions.

More specifically, ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, succession, and political memory connected individual actors with wider communities and political expectations. This finding is significant because it shows that personalisation in the Nigerian context cannot be understood solely as individual self-presentation. Political actors may function as symbolic representatives of collective identities, causing evaluations of individuals to acquire wider social and political meanings.

4. Personalisation and Affective Polarisation

The integrated findings provide the study's principal contribution by demonstrating how personalisation can facilitate affective polarisation. Linguistic resources construct political selves and others; pragmatic actions transform these representations into claims, evaluations, commitments, and appeals; and socio-cultural contexts connect individual actors with collective identities. The resulting self–other distinctions can therefore extend from individual politicians to the groups and values they are perceived to represent.

The contrast in *They want to divide this nation, but we will unite it* illustrates this process. The pronouns *they* and *we* construct opposing identities, while *divide* and *unite* assign contrasting political and moral values. Similar patterns arise when political actors are associated with ethnic, religious, regional, partisan, or national identities. Positive representations of the political self may encourage identification and solidarity, while negative representations of opponents may foster distrust and opposition.

This finding complements scholarship showing that political personalisation involves self-referential narratives, evaluation, emotional appeal, and identity construction (Opeibi, 2021; Osisanwo, 2016; Adegoju & Adetunji, 2020). However, the present study advances this scholarship by demonstrating how these dimensions interact to connect individual political evaluation with collective affective alignment. Affective polarisation therefore emerges not only through explicit hostility but also through cumulative patterns of positive self-presentation, negative other-presentation, and group identification.

5. Theoretical Contribution

The findings demonstrate the analytical value of integrating SFG, SAT, and EoC within Ayoola's (2008) pragma-functional orientation. SFG explains the linguistic construction of political persons; SAT accounts for the actions performed through these constructions; and EoC explains their socio-cultural situatedness. Their integration reveals how linguistic form, pragmatic action, and contextual meaning jointly transform individual political actors into focal points of legitimacy, identification, and opposition.

The study consequently conceptualises personalisation as a pragma-functional and socio-culturally situated mechanism of affective polarisation. Its contribution lies in showing how political competition becomes affectively organised when individual actors are constructed as embodiments of competing identities, values, interests, and political futures.

Conclusion

This study demonstrates that personalisation functions as a pragma-linguistic and socio-culturally situated mechanism through which political actors construct identities, negotiate legitimacy, organise collective affiliations, and contribute to affective polarisation in Nigerian adversarial political discourse. It extends beyond individual visibility to the interaction of linguistic choices, communicative actions, and socio-cultural contexts through which political meanings are produced and interpreted.

The SFG analysis showed that personalisation is realised through personal reference, naming, transitivity, modality, and appraisal. These resources foreground actors, attribute agency and responsibility, express authority and commitment, and construct favourable or unfavourable evaluations. SAT further demonstrated that personalised constructions perform political actions: representatives establish competence and achievement, commissives project commitment, directives mobilise audiences, expressives communicate evaluation and affiliation, and declaratives position speakers authoritatively. Presupposition and implicature convey evaluations and assumptions indirectly.

The EoC analysis established that these processes are mediated by socio-cultural contexts, including ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, political succession, representation, and shared political memory. Individual actors may consequently become associated with wider communities and collective interests.

Overall, affective polarisation emerges when personalised representations connect with collective identities and adversarial self–other distinctions. Political actors may be associated with competence, justice, achievement, or collective interests, while opponents are constructed through failure, exclusion, or incompetence. When these evaluations become attached to ethnic, religious, regional, partisan, or national identities, individual political evaluation can develop into group-based alignment and affective opposition. Personalisation is therefore not merely leader-centred communication but a mechanism through which linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural resources converge to organise political identification and affective division.

Contributions to Scholarship

The study makes five principal contributions. First, it reconceptualises personalisation as an integrated pragma-linguistic and socio-cultural process rather than merely increased leader visibility. Second, it contributes to affective polarisation research by showing how self–other representation, evaluation, and collective identification connect individual actors with affective political alignments. Third, it extends Nigerian political discourse scholarship by demonstrating how personalisation intersects with ethnicity, religion, regional affiliation, zoning, political succession, representation, and shared political memory. Fourth, it demonstrates the analytical value of integrating linguistic realisation, communicative action, and socio-cultural context through SFG, SAT, and EoC. Fifth, it advances the Integrated Pragma-Functional Sociocultural Analytical Model (IPFSAM) for examining political identity, legitimacy, adversarial representation, and affective polarisation.

Implications of the Study

The findings have theoretical, methodological, empirical, and democratic implications. Theoretically, they establish personalisation as linguistic, pragmatic, and socio-cultural, showing that the political significance of individual actors emerges through representation, action, and contextual interpretation. Methodologically, integrating SFG, SAT, and EoC provides a multidimensional basis for tracing discourse from linguistic form through pragmatic action to contextualised meaning.

Empirically, personalised discourse constructs legitimacy, attributes agency and responsibility, mobilises collective identities, and establishes adversarial distinctions. Democratically, personalisation may make political competition accessible by connecting complex issues to identifiable leaders and their records. However, excessive personalisation may weaken issue-based deliberation when competition becomes centred primarily on personalities and the identities they symbolise.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

The study is limited by its qualitative analysis of 171 purposively selected extracts from Nigerian political discourse produced between 2021 and 2023. While this provides interpretive depth, it does not establish the frequency or distribution of personalisation across a larger corpus. Future research could employ corpus-assisted methods to examine variation across actors, parties, media platforms, and electoral periods.

The focus on elite political discourse also leaves audience reception insufficiently examined. Future studies could investigate how citizens interpret personalised messages and whether particular constructions generate identification, trust, distrust, or resentment. Comparative research across subsequent Nigerian elections and other African democracies could further test the findings.

Future research could extend IPFSAM through Appraisal Theory, Framing Theory, Social Identity Theory, and Multimodal Discourse Analysis, particularly in digital political communication involving social media, images, videos, and memes. Studies could also examine personalisation in relation to populism, gender, political parties, and emerging communication technologies.

Overall, the study establishes personalisation as a multidimensional discourse process through which linguistic choices, communicative actions, and socio-cultural contexts construct political identities, legitimacy, collective affiliations, and affective divisions. Its central contribution is to show that personalisation matters not simply because it increases leader visibility, but because it makes political actors symbolic focal points through which identities, group boundaries, and emotional alignments are constructed and contested.

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